

than their modern counterparts—they were often made from animal membranes, such as sheep intestines, and people sometimes resorted to animal horns or shells. Condoms were also expensive; at the end of the 19th century in Britain, a dozen could cost up to 10 shillings—an average weekly wage.

Modern methods

Despite the contraceptive methods available, many women still had unwanted pregnancies due to a lack of knowledge about their reproductive system, or lack of access to contraceptives—in 1873, for example, the US Congress passed the Comstock Act to outlaw contraception. British sex educator Marie Stopes was a leading voice at the turn of the 20th century in advocating for contraceptives, and American Margaret Sanger helped to lessen the stigma around them when she coined the term “birth control” in the 1960s.

Contraception’s biggest innovation came in the 20th century. Work on developing an oral contraceptive began in the 1930s, and in 1960, the Food and Drug Administration approved the first pill, Enovid, in the US. The pill revolutionized women’s lives, giving them the power to enjoy sex without fear of pregnancy. However, among those who first took the pill in 1960, women reported problems such as blood clots, strokes, and depression. In 1969, Barbara Seaman published *The Doctor’s Case Against the Pill*, highlighting pill-related health concerns, and her work led to the Nelson Pill Hearings, in which activist Alice Wolfson accused the pharmaceutical industry of using 10 million American women

“Women’s **modern liberation** is inextricably **linked** to their ability to **control reproduction**.”

CAMILLE PAGLIA, “NO LAW IN THE ARENA,” 1995

as guinea pigs. The ability to choose if and when to become pregnant has had a huge social and economic impact on women—in terms of job opportunities, increased earning power, and admittance to college and university education. Today, most females in the West have access to contraception, and many of them are increasingly turning to long-term medical methods, such as hormone implants and intrauterine devices (IUDs). An estimated 222 million women in developing countries, however, still struggle to access contraceptives due to low funds, a lack of supply chains, and traditional beliefs.



▲ Modern-day condom

By the 20th century, condoms were mass-produced, but sold in discreet packaging due to the stigma against birth control—condoms were seen as an incentive for immoral behavior. This tin condom case was created in New York in 1929.

“No woman can **call herself free** who does not **own** and **control her body**. No woman can **call herself free** until she can **choose consciously** whether **she will or will not** be a **mother**.”

MARGARET SANGER, *WOMAN AND THE NEW RACE*, 1920